

Dunne and dusted

After the resignation of the High-Performance Director, whose selection criteria and training methods **came under the scanner**, India's boxers and coaches will have to find their own path ahead of the next Qualifier.

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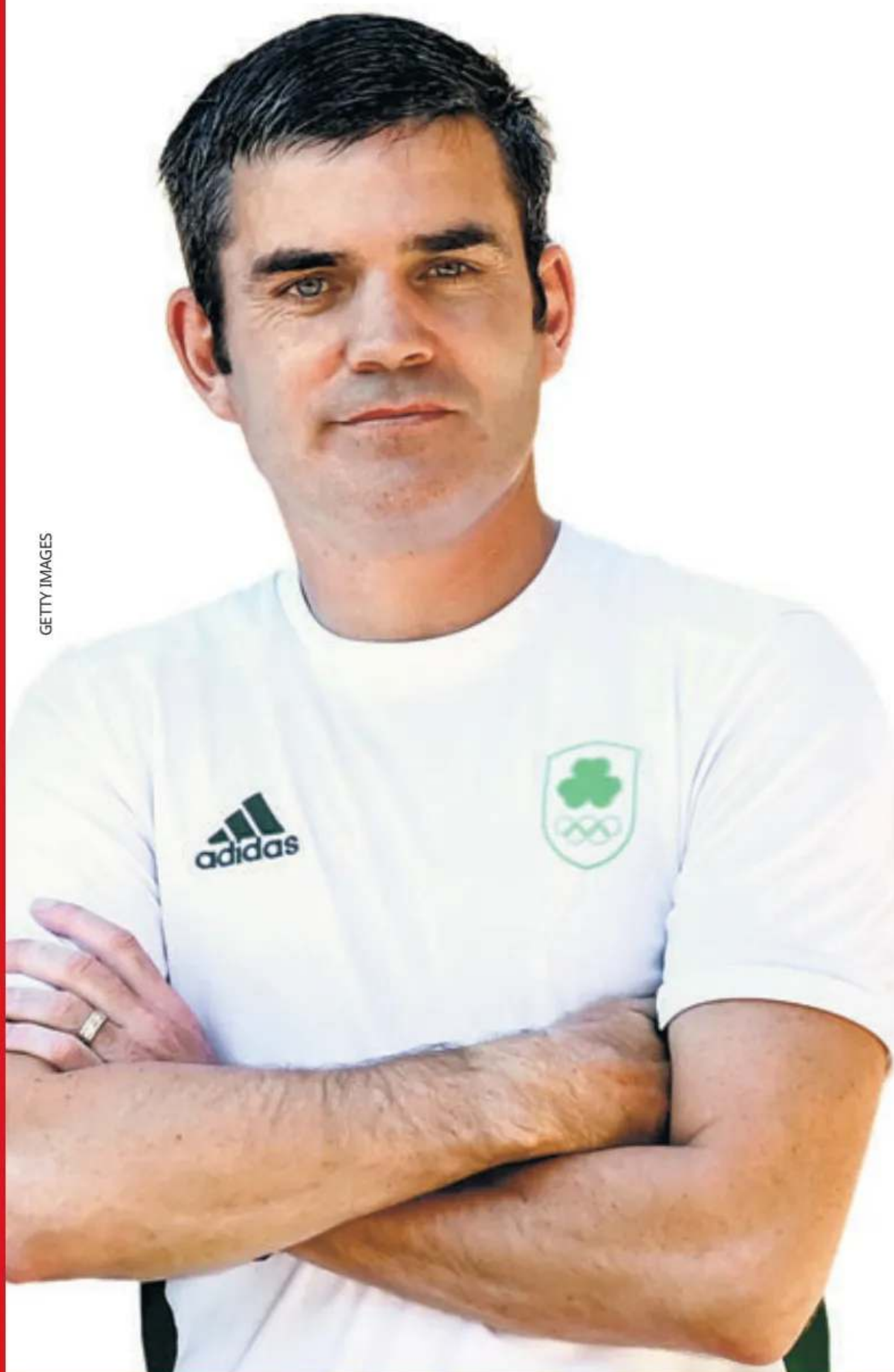
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In January 2023, over a video conference call with Indian coaches and officials of the Boxing Federation of India, Bernard Dunne (the newly appointed High-Performance Director of Indian boxing) laid out his plan for the sport in the country. Dunne (left), a former professional world champion, had a radical new approach to training compared to how things had been done previously.

Indian national camps, said Dunne, would feature only two boxers in each weight class — in contrast to the four being previously accommodated. The camps would only be organised for boxers in the 12 Olympic weight categories (seven for men and six for women). Most significantly, teams for major competitions like the Asian Games, World Championships, or Olympic qualifiers would be selected based on an internal assessment by himself and the coaches rather than through trials, as was the case earlier.

Dunne's plans would come in for criticism during the call itself. It is learnt that one senior coach said the proposals would be the 'end of Indian boxing'. As it turned out, Dunne would get his way. Within a few months, coaches who weren't willing to buy into Dunne's vision found themselves sidelined. Narender Rana, the national men's coach, is currently posted in Assam, while the women's coach, Bhaskar Bhatt, was transferred to work with youth women boxers in Hisar.

A little over a year after that video



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